The Free Colony

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[Dedication goes here.]

Act One — Clause 9.4.2 {#act-one-clause-942}

Day 0 — Earth, signing day

Chapter One — Clause 9.4.2

Forty-seven people in a room designed for thirty, and not one of them was happy about it.

Cole Maren sat in a chair that cost someone at Asterlyne a lot of points in a procurement spreadsheet—cheap enough that nobody would notice the line item, expensive enough to signal that this process mattered. Professional. Controlled. The kind of seating that said: *We take you seriously, but not too seriously, because if you were serious people, you wouldn't be here.*

The waiting room smelled like new plastic and the desperation everyone was pretending not to emit. Fluorescent ceiling panels buzzed at a frequency Cole could feel in his molars. A tablet on the low table in front of him displayed the charter—all 247 pages of it, not the 200 they'd claimed in the recruitment materials. He'd started counting on page one and hadn't stopped.

Around him, people were talking. Not talking, really. Performing the social shapes of talking—the woman to his left asking the woman next to her whether she'd done the medical screening, both of them knowing the answer was yes, both of them needing the distraction of words. The man in the corner—contractor's shoulders, calloused hands, not the type to volunteer for anything unless there was something urgent he was running from—staring at a tablet with the concentration of someone who'd decided not to read.

Cole read.

He had the luxury of being methodical. Nobody here knew him. Nobody was going to ask why he wasn't pacing the way the young guy near the door was pacing, or networking the way the two botanists in the corner seemed to be networking, trading names and institutional affiliations like they were at a conference instead of a one-way ticket off Earth. Cole could sit. Could read. Could let the fluorescent light strip the personality out of his face until he looked like he belonged here—which is to say, he looked like someone with nothing better to do.

The contract was written in English, which was kind. It could have been written in legalese—that subspecies of English that used all the same words but rearranged them to prevent understanding. But this contract was designed to be read. Just not *by* the signatories. The structure was forward-facing, user-friendly, the language was clear, the sections labeled sensibly. A person reading it in good faith would arrive at a different understanding than a person reading it carefully.

Cole read carefully.

Section 1: Organizational Charter of the Free Colonial Initiative, Parcel 16b Settlement.

All colonists agreed to the terms without qualification, without amendment, without negotiation. Fine. Nobody negotiated with Asterlyne. That wasn't the system.

Sections 2–5: the basic infrastructure. Settlement boundaries. Resource allocation. Command structure. A temporary governance council elected by majority vote, authority subordinate to the Company Safety Officer, who retained final decision-making on all matters of environmental management and resource distribution.

The woman next to Cole glanced down at his tablet. He felt her looking. He didn't move, didn't look back, just kept reading. She went back to not reading hers.

Section 6: Ownership and Land Rights.

This was where people usually started skimming.

Upon successful establishment of self-sustaining agricultural capacity and the passage of five (5) Earth years, title to Parcel 16b shall transfer to the colonist collective, contingent upon maintenance of charter

compliance and population threshold stabilization.

Cole read that sentence three times.

Population threshold stabilization.

He flipped to the appendices. Nobody flipped to the appendices. The appendices were where you found the definitions that made you understand what you'd actually agreed to.

Clause 9.4.1: Definition of "colonist collective."

Ownership stake in Parcel 16b (upon transfer) shall be distributed equally among all original signatories to this charter present and alive on Year Five, Day One, beginning at 0000 hours UTC+7. Signatories who voluntarily depart the settlement, fail to renew charter consent, or are deceased shall forfeit their stake and have such stake distributed pro-rata among remaining signatories.

Okay. Straightforward. Forty-seven of them now. If someone left early, the pie got smaller, but their slice got bigger. People understood that math. It was a motivator—every person who stayed made everyone else's stake slightly larger. Asterlyne was good at architecture like that. Creating incentives that looked aligned but actually severed the group's interest from their survival.

Clause 9.4.2: Stabilization Threshold.

Transfer of title shall occur only if, at Year Five Day One, no fewer than fifty-one percent (51%) of original signatories remain alive and present at the settlement. Should this threshold not be met, title shall revert to Asterlyne Corporation in perpetuity, along with all improvements and resources thereupon. No compensation to colonists or next of kin shall be due.

Cole set the tablet down.

He looked at it on the table like it had grown teeth.

Forty-seven people. Fifty-one percent of forty-seven was 23.97. Functionally, twenty-four. You needed twenty-four people alive in five years, out of the forty-seven who started, to own anything.

You needed to lose twenty-three people.

He picked the tablet back up. Read it again to make sure he hadn't miscalculated—he hadn't, his math was exact, and that was the problem. Twenty-three. Less than fifty percent of the people in this room could be dead and the survivors still get the land.

Or put differently: more than half the people in this room had to be dead.

Cole looked up from the screen.

The contractor was still not reading his tablet. The woman next to him was reading the same page she'd been reading five minutes ago. The botanists were talking about soil chemistry, their voices settling into the kind of comfortable technical discussion that meant they'd probably worked together before, probably had a history that didn't start in this room. Near the window, a younger guy—couldn't be more than twenty-two, twenty-three—was rereading the same section over and over, his leg bouncing with the kind of focused anxiety that suggested he was trying very hard to understand something he was afraid to understand.

Cole counted the room. There were the two botanists. The contractor. The woman next to him. The bouncing kid. A doctor, fifties, calm, reading with the measured attention of someone used to processing medical literature. A small cluster of three in the corner who seemed to know each other—energy efficient, probably academic, the type who came to this because they'd burned through their funding and a charter settlement sounded like a field opportunity. Four people he hadn't classified yet. The facilitator, who was polished and

bored in exactly the way that suggested she'd watched forty-seven batches of desperate people sign away their rights to land they'd never own.

Forty-seven faces.

Cole looked at each one and asked himself the same question: How many of these people will be dead five years from now?

Not will choose to leave. Not will want to go home. *Will be dead.*

The contractor had an old scar on his jaw that suggested he was good at surviving. That was one point in his favor. The bouncing kid looked like he couldn't survive a bad meal, but youth was its own strategy—faster healing, better reflexes, less likelihood of pre-existing conditions. The doctor had calloused fingertips that came from years of something—surgery, probably. Surgical hands were attached to people who made complicated decisions under pressure. That usually meant longevity.

He was still counting when the facilitator stood.

"We're ready to begin," she said. Her name was Melissa. It was on her badge. She said it the way you'd say: *We're ready to start the experiment.*

They were ushered down a hallway into a smaller room with individual signing stations—corporate ergonomics, each one separated by a divider so nobody had to watch anyone else sign. Privacy theater. Nobody needed privacy to sign away their rights, but it was more comfortable for everyone if they pretended they did.

Cole took his station. His tablet displayed the full charter, pre-populated with his name: COLE MAREN. His background check was complete. His medical clearance was already noted. His initial investment of fifty thousand credits—everything he'd been saving, everything he still owed on the loan that made the fifty thousand possible—was documented. His signature would make it binding.

He didn't sign immediately.

He ran through the math again.

Twenty-four alive. Fifty-one percent. Year five. Five years from day one until the clause invoked. Not five years from now—five years from the day they landed, from the moment the shuttle touched down on Parcel 16b and they became subject to the full weight of the charter.

In five years, Cole would be forty-three. He had almost no dependents anymore. Lily was nine. He'd had custody three years ago, had held it like a trophy he'd won and didn't know how to carry, had let it slip through his hands the way he let everything slip through his hands eventually because he was good at logistics but terrible at presence. He'd been present for documents and court dates and the standard visitation schedule, which is to say he hadn't been present at all.

His ex-wife had filed for full custody eighteen months ago. She hadn't needed to file hard. He'd already surrendered the space where being a father lived.

He thought about Lily at nine, probably taller now than he remembered. The last visit had been awkward. She'd drawn a horse in colored pencil and asked if he wanted to keep it, and he'd said yes, and he meant it, and then he'd left it on the table when he walked out to meet with a recruiter for Asterlyne because his shift had run over and he needed to close the door on something, anything, to stop the feeling that everything he touched fell through his hands.

The horse was probably in a recycle bin somewhere.

He'd gotten the recruitment email the next day. It had landed in his inbox like an answer to a prayer he hadn't quite had the courage to articulate.

Cole signed.

He used the stylus on the tablet and dragged his name across the signature box. Official. Binding. Witnessed by the timestamp and the biometric scan and the satellite uplink that would render this document legally immutable.

He'd just bet forty-three-year-old version of himself, five years from now, that he would be alive and on Parcel 16b and part of a group of twenty-four survivors.

He'd bet it all—the money, the custody, the apartment, the visits to Lily that had already become quarterly and were trending toward never—on clause 9.4.2.

On the fact that he could count.

On the fact that if you counted carefully enough, you could make the math work. You could read what was written even when nobody wanted you to read it. You could understand what was being asked of you even when nobody would articulate the question.

Twenty-three people. That's what it cost.

He wasn't hoping nobody died. That would be stupid. People always died. Disease, accident, bad luck, the simple arithmetic of time. On Earth, people died too. At least here, the math was clear.

He walked out of the signing room into the hallway where the other forty-six people were filing out of their own stations, each one carrying the same tablet, each one having just signed the same charter, each one presumably having read the same clause.

Or not. Probably not.

Most of them looked like they'd been reading the user-friendly sections, the parts that promised land and ownership and a fresh start. Most of them weren't looking at the man in the corridor the way Cole was looking at them—the way you might look at a group of assets and try to calculate which ones would hold their value.

"First time off-world?" a voice asked.

Cole turned. It was the contractor. Scarred jaw, contractor's hands, the expression of someone who'd learned to ask careful questions.

"Yes," Cole said.

"Me too." The contractor didn't offer his hand. Just stood there, evaluating. "Thought about the statistics?"

"What statistics?"

"Frontier mortality. Any Asterlyne settlement. They don't advertise it, but if you actually read the charter—" He stopped. Something flickered across his face. Recognition, maybe. "You read the charter."

"Yes."

"Did you get to clause 9.4.2?"

Cole didn't answer immediately. He was reassessing the contractor. The scarred jaw suggested violence, or proximity to it. The careful questions suggested intelligence. The fact that he'd gotten to clause 9.4.2 and understood what it meant suggested he was the kind of man who read things all the way through.

"I read it," Cole said.

"Twenty-four out of forty-seven," the contractor said, not a question.

"Yes."

The contractor looked down the hallway at the other colonists filing out. "I'm Garrett Polk. And I think what they've done to us is a lot uglier than what the frontier does on its own."

He walked away before Cole could answer.

Cole stood in the empty hallway and heard the fluorescent hum buzzing in his skull, felt it in his teeth, and understood that Garrett Polk had just said something true. The frontier wasn't what would kill them. The contract was. The math was. The simple, elegant arithmetic of a charter that only transferred ownership if enough of you died to make you small enough to own.

Cole had signed up for the frontier.

He'd actually signed up for the margin.

And he was betting the next five years of his life that he could be the person counting the remaining faces at the end.

Chapter Two — Transit

Three months in recycled air tastes like someone else's exhalation mixed with industrial scrubbers. Cole learned to stop noticing it by week two, which meant he'd learned to stop noticing a lot of things. The Asterlyne transport vessel wasn't designed for comfort. It was designed for efficiency and just enough habitability to keep the cargo alive until delivery.

The crew of forty-seven had settled into the lower decks like sediment. Bunks in columns of four. A common mess that doubled as the orientation room. A medical bay where Haruki Sato—the doctor, the calm one, the man who'd introduced himself by asking everyone their medical history instead of their name—had already organized a basic clinic. Exercise equipment that nobody used because moving in 0.7G made the stomach betray you.

Cole spent most of his time reading.

The charter existed in full digital copy on the ship's network, along with supplementary materials: geological surveys, atmospheric data, agricultural projections, structural schematics. Personnel files. He started with the geological surveys and worked backward into the historical data, into the notes that suggested, in careful corporate language, that Parcel 16b had been surveyed before. Once. Seven years ago. By an expedition that Asterlyne had mentioned nowhere in the recruitment materials.

It was the kind of thing you'd find if you looked. Most people didn't look.

Most people were doing what they were doing in the common mess on the forty-fifth day of transit: clustering into smaller groups, forming the soft hierarchies that would become the harder hierarchies once gravity meant something again. The two botanists from the initial signing—colleagues from an Earth research institute, both women, both operating under the assumption that the settlement would have built-in scientific infrastructure—had claimed a table and were planning projects. The contractor, Polk, had gathered about eight people around him and was talking about freedom in a way that suggested he'd given this speech before. Three academics who didn't quite know each other yet but recognized the type—the kind of people who'd chased this opportunity because their funding had ended, because they had nothing else to lose, because an off-world colony looked like a second act.

Ren Tsai was at a table alone, reviewing something on her personal tablet that made her frown.

Cole had learned her name from the orientation materials. Engineer. Specialty: structural systems and environmental management. She'd been quiet during the embarkation process but had asked three questions during the first orientation presentation that had made the facilitators visibly uncomfortable: questions about the gap between the projected resource allocations and the documented planetary volatility, questions about failover systems if primary water processing failed, questions about what happened to a settlement if the Company Safety Officer position became unexpectedly vacant.

The facilitators had given the kind of answers that were technically true and completely unhelpful.

Ren had written down their answers anyway, which meant she understood that documentation mattered more than satisfaction.

Cole carried his meal tray to her table. It was a violation of the soft social rules—you didn't join someone sitting alone unless they invited you. But Cole was good at calculating when rules could be bent.

"Can I sit?" he asked.

Ren looked up. She was older than he'd initially thought—maybe mid-thirties instead of late twenties. Her face was the kind that stayed still when it was thinking, which made the moments when it moved mean something. It moved now.

"Sure," she said.

Cole sat. The chair was the kind engineered for low-G comfort, which meant it felt like sitting on a marshmallow someone had wrapped in steel.

"You asked good questions," Cole said.

"They didn't answer any of them," Ren said.

"That's usually how you know they're good questions."

Ren set down her tablet. Up close, Cole could see what she'd been reading: the resource allocation spreadsheet, compared to what looked like her own calculations. She'd been checking the math. Probably finding it didn't add up.

"What's your background?" she asked.

"Logistics. Inventory management, supply chain optimization, that kind of thing."

"So you count things."

"I keep things from running out."

Ren nodded like this explained something. It did. He could see her recalibrating what she was looking at—not just information anymore, but a problem. And problems needed people who could count.

"Why did you sign up?" she asked.

Cole had an answer prepared for this question. It was true and incomplete: "Earth didn't need me anymore. Out there, I might."

It was the kind of answer that closed conversations gently. Ren didn't push. But she looked at him the way someone looks at a calculation they don't quite believe yet, and he knew she was reading the deflection accurately. She understood that he'd answered a different question than the one she'd asked.

She didn't call him on it.

"I'm Ren," she said, and went back to her tablet.

Cole ate his meal—some kind of protein cultivate that had the texture of foam and the flavor of commitment to nutrition—and watched the common mess reorganize itself. The academics had merged with the contractor's group. The botanists had separated, one going to find Haruki in the medical bay, the other settling in with a book. The young guy—Joss Carver, Cole had learned his name from the manifest—was doing what he'd been doing since embarkation: reading the charter, panicking at sections, re-reading them, panicking again.

The contractor, Polk, was laughing about something. Not a happy laugh. The kind of laugh that lived in the space between humor and anger, the sound of a man who'd learned to make jokes about things that had broken him.

By the sixty-third day, Cole had learned the rhythms of the ship well enough to move through it without thinking. He knew which paths connected the medical bay to the agricultural storage without passing through the common mess. He knew when Ren went to the exercise equipment and came back all motion and sharp breathing. He knew that Dana Wen, the botanist who avoided eye contact, did her heavy work in the agricultural lab in the early hours, when nobody else was awake.

He'd organized his own analysis by then. Built a quiet spreadsheet in a private partition of the ship's network. Listed forty-six names (he already knew Garrett Polk's assessment—the man had approached him

in the corridor that first day with the kind of familiarity that suggested he'd seen something in Cole recognize something in him). Coded them by skill set, by apparent psychological resilience, by the things they'd admitted in casual conversation about why they'd signed.

It was a monster's work, really. Ranking people by survival probability.

But Cole had stopped caring about being anything other than useful.

Polk found him in the observation deck three weeks before planet-fall, the section of the ship where the port looked out at nothing—vast dark, occasional stars, the slow crawl toward Parcel 16b visible only as a brightening dot among the other fixed lights.

Polk was writing something on a napkin. Numbers. Calculations. The kind of thing someone did when they were trying to convince themselves that the math worked out a different way than it actually did.

Cole watched from across the observation area, not hiding it.

When Polk realized he was being observed, he crumpled the napkin. The instinct was immediate. Guilty. But the guilt wasn't about having written the numbers. It was about Cole seeing him do it.

Polk looked up. He was good at reading people, Cole could see that now. Had been good at it for a long time, probably. Probably it was why he was here and not wherever he'd come from.

"You read the whole thing," Polk said. Not a question.

Cole nodded.

Polk's face shifted. Not relaxing exactly. Settling into something. "Yeah. Yeah, I thought so." He looked out at the dark for a moment. "Then you know what it actually costs."

Cole knew exactly what it cost.

"I do," he said.

Polk crumpled the napkin tighter, then released it, smoothed it against his thigh. Twenty-three showed on the paper in his calculations, the same number Cole had arrived at. But Polk's twenty-three looked like a sentence. Cole's looked like arithmetic.

"You resigned to it?" Polk asked. "That's what it looks like. Like you've already accepted the math."

Cole didn't correct him. Let Polk believe that resignation and calculation were the same thing. It was useful.

"You're the first person I've met here," Polk continued, "who actually seems like they understood what they signed. Most of them..." He gestured toward the corridor, toward the common mess, toward the forty-six people who'd climbed aboard Asterlyne's ship and made a deal with the frontier and the contract and their own mortality. "Most of them think they're going to a new world. I think they're actually just going to run the same games from somewhere different. But you know. You know what this actually is."

Cole watched Polk's face. Saw the specific flavor of his desperation—not fear of death, but anger at systems that made survival look optional. Not new anger. Old anger. The kind that had probably brought him here in the first place.

"What did you leave behind?" Cole asked.

Polk looked at him for a long moment. "Everything that mattered. That's the point of a charter settlement, isn't it? You come because Earth broke you. The planet either fixes you or finishes the job." He stood, pocketed the crumpled napkin. "I'm betting on finish."

He walked out before Cole could answer, and Cole realized that Polk had misread him in a way that was useful. Polk thought Cole was a fellow traveler in resignation. Didn't understand that resignation and strategy looked identical from the outside, but they were entirely different machines.

Cole was already reading the weather projections. Already modeling the agricultural failure vectors. Already calculating which skills would matter in months two and three and twelve when Earth was a memory and the supply drops became theoretical.

He wasn't resigned.

He was building the mathematics of survival.

The final orientation briefing happened five days before planet-fall. All forty-seven colonists gathered in the common mess. A facilitator—not Melissa from the signing station, someone new, someone even more polished and bored—presented the settlement overview.

Parcel 16b. Coordinates. Atmospheric composition. Seasonal cycles. Agricultural viability index. She said the word *index* with the precision of someone reading from a tablet, which is exactly what she was doing.

"The viability index for this parcel," the facilitator said, "has been measured at eighty-four."

Cole looked up from his own tablet, where he'd been cross-referencing the geological survey data.

Eighty-four.

He pulled up the original survey document. Searched the appendices. Found the viability index calculation.

Seventy-two.

Seventy-two from a survey conducted seven years ago under conditions that might or might not have changed. The recruitment materials had claimed eighty-four. A difference of twelve points. The difference between optimism and actual capability. The difference between a projectable settlement timeline and a question mark.

He looked at Ren across the mess. She was looking at him, had been looking at him, had clearly noticed the discrepancy at the same moment and was watching to see if he'd registered it. When their eyes met, she looked away—not dismissive, just confirming. You saw it. I saw it. The question became: what were they going to do about a lie that was buried in supplementary materials that most people wouldn't read?

The facilitator continued her presentation, and Cole returned to his spreadsheet, to his calculations, to the mathematics of scarcity and survival.

The brochure had promised eighty-four.

The planet, he suspected, would deliver seventy-two.

And the colony would have to make the difference work with four thousand kilometers of distance and five years of solitude and the kind of mathematics that only looked simple until you had to live inside it.

Cole started a new column in his spreadsheet.

He labeled it: *Margin for Error*.

He left the cell empty.

He didn't know yet what number should go there, or even if any number was possible.

But he was going to find out.